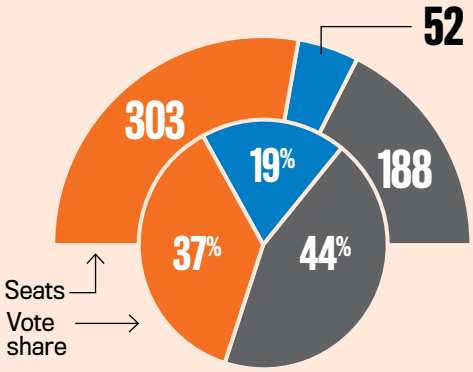
**Prime Minister Narendra Modi,** like all successful political leaders, has a panoptic vision, which, accompanied by an inspiring narrative, helps him identify key battles. He then draws up deft strategies of attack, strikes at the most opportune moment, even leading from the front if need be, to vanquish any opposition he may encounter. Qualities that he demonstrated in full measure in the recently-concluded assembly elections. The stakes were high both for Modi and the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), since this was the final round of assembly polls before the all-important General Election 2024. Together, the aspiration is to notch a third successive Lok Sabha victory—a feat only India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, and the Congress have accomplished so far. And win not just a full majority but one of the kind that Rajiv Gandhi pulled off in the 1984 general election after Indira Gandhi's assassination, when the Congress bagged 414 out of the 543 seats in the Lok Sabha, the highest-ever majority any party has won since Independence. The Congress had cornered a 46.4 per cent vote share at the time to reach that pinnacle. The BJP's highest vote percentage, by contrast, has been 37.3 per cent, in the 2019 general election, when it won 303 seats on its own. Its target this time is a 50 per cent vote share, along with its allies in the National Democratic Alliance (NDA). Winning a third term will put Modi in the league of statesmen, a mantle that Nehru had worn.

To turbocharge its endeavour for total political dominance, the Modi-led BJP deemed it essential that it win in the three Hindi heartland states—Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh—that were going to the polls in November along with Telangana and Mizoram. To their dismay, the Congress, the BJP's arch-rival, seemed to be staging a spirited comeback, wresting power from them in Himachal Pradesh and Karnataka late last year and in mid-2023, respectively. Worse, surveys showed the Grand Old Party at an advantage in the three northern poll-bound states, too, and experiencing a rebirth in the southern state of Telangana, where the BJP had begun to fancy its chances. Meanwhile, the Opposition, with Congress in the lead, combined its forces under the banner of INDIA, or the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, a 28-party coalition that soon armed itself with the potent narrative of increasing reservations for backward classes after caste-based surveys. It was a direct threat to the monolithic Hindutva plank the BJP had so diligently crafted over the past few years and which had yielded them rich dividends in state and general elections.

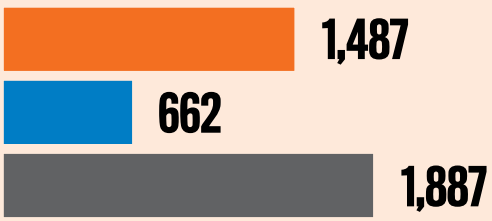
Conscious of this hydra-headed challenge coming their way, Modi, along with his master strategist, the Union home minister Amit Shah, and BJP national president J.P. Nadda,

## HOW THE BJP AND CONGRESS ARE PLACED

### LOK SABHA
(2019 Results)
Total seats 543




### ASSEMBLIES
(Dec. 2023)
Total seats 4,036




BJP CONGRESS OTHERS

**BJP IS THE FRONTRUNNER FOR 2024, BUT HAS LITTLE PRESENCE IN THE SOUTH, OR HEFT IN THE EAST. MORE THAN MATH, THE PARTY WILL NEED MODI'S CHEMISTRY TO SEE IT THROUGH**